The Lake Was Always There

A Life of Ruth Calder

SAM CALDER

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Written from recorded interviews with Ruth Calder. Every fact and quotation traces to the original recordings, which are preserved by the family.
Set in EB Garamond.

For everyone who sat at that kitchen table.

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INTRODUCTION

I recorded my grandmother twice in the summer of 2024, at her kitchen table, with my phone propped against the sugar bowl. This book is made from those two conversations. Everything in it comes from what she said; where she wasn't sure, the book isn't either.

This is the Lineage sample project. Ruth Calder, her family and the recordings are invented.

THOSE WHO CAME BEFORE

CHAPTER 1

OTHERS IN THE FAMILY

NORWAY AND DULUTH · ABOUT 1900

On Boots and Ore Boats

What Ruth knew about her grandfather came to her the way most family history comes: from her father, who told it often. Where the records and the family part company, this chapter says so; for Anders, no records have been consulted yet, so everything here is the family's account.

The Calders came from Norway. Anders Calder crossed the Atlantic on a ship at sixteen, "or that's what my father always said," Ruth added, and he did it in one pair of boots, which he wore the whole way across. "My father loved to tell that one."

In Duluth he found work on the ore boats, loading iron ore at the docks. "That's where the work was," Ruth said.

THE RECORDS

What this chapter rests on. Two passages of Ruth's recorded interview (session S1). No documents have been consulted. A passenger list or naturalization record would confirm or correct the crossing; see facts/gaps.md.

THE LINE OF DESCENT

Anders Calder (link from Norway unconfirmed)
↓
Ruth's father
↓
Ruth Calder (b. 1938) = Walt
↓
their children and grandchildren

HER LIFE

CHAPTER 2

THE ORE DOCK

DULUTH, MINNESOTA · 1938–1950

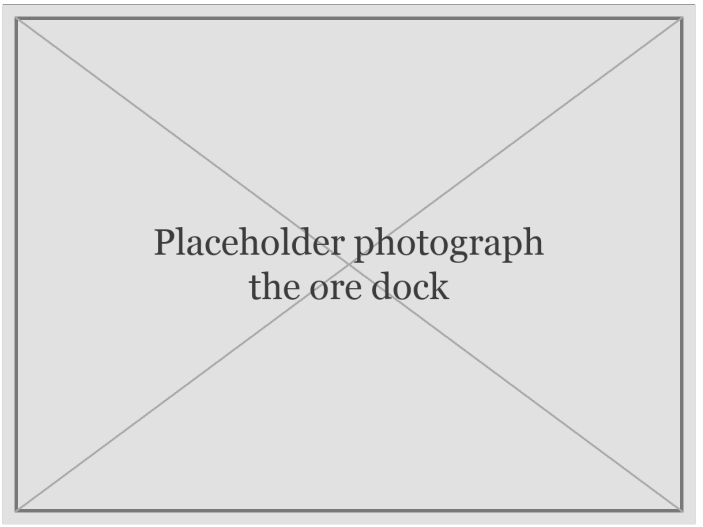
On Tin Pails and Tunnels

Ruth Calder was born in Duluth, Minnesota, in 1938.

When she was seven or eight, as best she remembered, Ruth walked her father's lunch down to the ore dock in a tin pail. The dock was so tall "you had to tip your head all the way back," and the trains ran right out on top of it. Whether it frightened her, she never quite settled: "No. Well, yeah. A little."

❧

The big snow came around 1950, as Ruth remembered it. The school closed for a week, and she and her brother Pete dug a tunnel from the porch to the street. Pete proposed that they live in it. "Mother did not agree."



PLACEHOLDER: A PHOTOGRAPH OF THE ORE DOCK [P001]

CHAPTER 3

WALT AND THE CABIN

MINNEAPOLIS AND PIKE LAKE · 1956–1968

On Shoes, Sore Feet and a Roof

In 1956 Ruth went down to Minneapolis for three years of nursing school.

The students lived in a dormitory, and the house mother inspected their shoes every morning. "Every morning! As if the patients were going to look at our shoes."

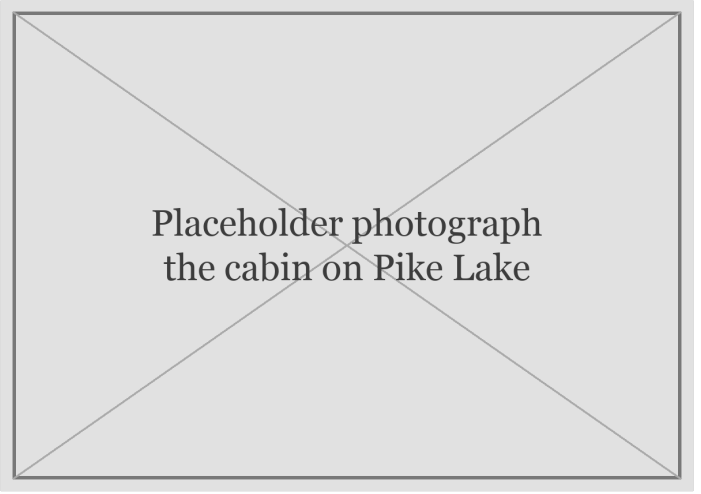
❧

⟦BRIDGE: Three years later, the thing she remembered best about Minneapolis had nothing to do with nursing.⟧

She met Walt at a church dance in 1959. Walt could not dance at all; he stepped on her feet the whole night and then asked if he could walk her home. "I said, well, my feet can't take much more of this, but all right."

❧

Starting in 1964 or so, Ruth and Walt built a cabin on Pike Lake with their own hands. It took four summers. Walt did the walls and Ruth did the roof, because Walt was afraid of heights. "Nobody believes that," she said.



PLACEHOLDER: THE CABIN ON PIKE LAKE ⟦P002⟧

What she valued most about it was simple. “The lake was always there. Whatever else happened, the lake was always there.”

NOTES AND RECORDS

A TIMELINE

about 1945	Ruth walks her father's lunch to the ore dock.
around 1950	The big snow; school closed for a week.
1956	Ruth begins three years of nursing school.
1959	Ruth meets Walt at a church dance.
1964 or so	Ruth and Walt build the cabin on Pike Lake.

GLOSSARY

house mother — A woman who supervised a student dormitory and the students' conduct.

ore dock — A very tall wooden or steel pier where railroad cars dumped iron ore down chutes into the holds of ships.

WHERE THE RECORDS ARE

What survives of the family's papers, photographs and keepsakes, and who looks after them as of this printing. Items remembered but now lost are listed too, so no one spends years looking.

Documents

Ruth's nursing-school diploma (1959). Mentioned in conversation; not yet seen. Kept by unknown. *The school's alumni office may hold a copy.*

Recordings

The original interview recordings (2024). Two sessions recorded by Sam Calder. Kept by Sam Calder, the family.

ABOUT THE RECORDINGS

This book was made from recorded conversations between Ruth Calder and Sam Calder. The recordings were transcribed word for word, and every passage in the book was checked against them. Every fact in the narrative comes from what she said, and every quotation is in her own words, with only filler words and false starts removed.

Session	Recording	Date	Length
S1	sample-session-1	2024-06-02	00:01:04
S2	sample-session-2	2024-06-09	00:01:02

The original recordings are kept by the family; see Where the Records Are.

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